

There are a few points I believe need to be made with regard to the proposed rules.

First, our background: My wife and I are avid cruisers, and are not employed or affiliated with any cruise line. So we're neutral parties. We have had two cruises cancelled (twice each) and were offered either our money back or 125% back in the form of a future cruise credit (on each of the first cancellations). For both cancellations, HAL re-booked us for the following year but gave us the option to opt out. So we believe Holland America was more than fair. I can't speak for other cruise lines or other passenger's experiences, but we accept the terms of the contract when we book the cruise.

But now your commission is going to step in & tell the cruise industry how to manage cancellations and refunds in a way that's contrary to the signed contract? I find that unsettling and, especially after the way the CDC shut down the cruise industry for over a year and then imposed draconian restrictions to let cruising start again, actions like these could be the last nail in the coffin of some cruise lines.

In the article I read, the proposed rules model federal airline rules. The problem with that is that if the CDC had modeled their treatment of the cruise industry after the airline rules, the no sail order would have been more like a requirement to meet certain safety criteria before resuming....something that only came over a year later. So saying that cruise rules should be similar to airline rules after the cruise lines had been begging to be treated like airlines for over a year seems contradictory and gives the impression that the federal government is targeting cruise lines. They're obviously in full survival mode right now until they can get all their ships back at sea with passengers. Allowing them to continue to follow agreements that passengers accepted should be automatic.

Cruises are leisure activities for those of us who can afford them; none of us passengers are going to be evicted from our homes because we can't make mortgage payments or starve if we don't get immediate refunds. While we appreciate our government's concern for us passengers, your commission's involvement needs to also take into account the fact that your actions could have unintended consequences. Most of the crew on those ships are from countries that have suffered so much more than we have here in the US, and they rely on those jobs to provide for their families and support the economies back home. Any additional restrictions on cruise lines would place additional burdens on cruise lines right when each line's survival is very much still in play. Anything that might delay in getting the remainder of the ships in service, such as the financial impact of more government intervention, would absolutely have a negative impact on the lives of the crew that can't get back aboard to earn their livelihood. I know they aren't American citizens, but us cruisers have a deep concern for their needs. As fellow humans, your commission should take that into account.

As long as passengers aren't being told that we'll get nothing (neither a future cruise nor a refund), and as long as they're honoring the contract as written and accepted there is no need for the federal government to be involved.

Sincerely,

Doug & Maria Cone